

YOU FOUND THE CHATS.

DON'T CONFRONT HIM YET

Here's exactly what to do in
the **first 72 hours**, before you
say a word.



THE CONNECTION CODE

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Before You Start

If you are reading this, there is a good chance you found something in the last few hours or days. A chat. A photo. A name saved under a man's name that isn't a man. A second phone.

This book is written for that moment. It is not a book about how to keep a husband, and it is not a book telling you to leave one. It is a plan for the next 72 hours and the 30 days after, so that whatever you decide, you decide it with a clear head and with your health, your money and your dignity protected.

HOW TO READ THIS

If you only have ten minutes, read Chapter 1 tonight. It tells you what not to do while you are still in shock. Read the rest over the next two days, before you speak to him.

IF YOU ARE NOT SAFE

If he has ever hit you, threatened you, controlled your movement or your money, or if you are afraid of what he will do when he finds out you know, go straight to Chapter 9 before anything else. Confrontation advice is for women who are safe. Your safety comes first.

ABOUT THE STORIES IN THIS BOOK

The short stories used as examples are composites, built from patterns many women describe. They are not one real woman's story and no real person is described. Where a real person or publication is quoted, the source is named.

INTRODUCTION: The Phone In Your Hand

It is late. The house is quiet. Maybe he is asleep beside you. Maybe he is in the shower and his phone lit up on the bed.

You saw it. And now your heart is beating so hard you can hear it.

Every part of you wants to do something. Wake him. Throw the phone at him. Call his mother. Call your sister. Send the other woman a message she will never forget. Post it.

Please don't. Not yet.

Why "not yet"

Not because you should be quiet. Not because you should "endure." Not because a good wife pretends she didn't see.

Because the first person to speak in shock usually loses.

If you confront him tonight, he gets to choose the story. He deletes what he can. He tells you it's nothing. He says you are crazy, insecure, a snoop. He calls his people before you call yours. He moves money you didn't know about. And you, exhausted and shaking, end up apologising for checking his phone.

If you wait 72 hours, you get to choose. You will know what you actually found. Your health and money will be protected. You will have decided who to tell. And when you finally speak, you will speak once, calmly, with the words already in your mouth.

THE WHOLE IDEA OF THIS BOOK

Waiting is not weakness. Waiting is preparation. You are not deciding whether to say something. You are deciding when, and making sure that when you do, it counts.

What this book will do

It walks you through the order that protects you: the first hour, the first three days, the confrontation, the people around you, the weeks after, and the decision about what comes next.

It gives you exact words, eleven scripts, for the conversations you are dreading most, including the one with your own mother.

What it will not do

It won't tell you that "all men cheat" and you should manage it. You will hear that enough from other people.

It won't tell you to leave. That decision belongs to you, and Chapter 7 helps you make it.

It won't teach you to spy, trap or manipulate him. Those tactics feel powerful at 2am and leave you worse off by morning.

It won't promise to save your marriage. Nothing honest can promise that. What it can promise is that you will come through this with your head up.

CHAPTER 1: The First Hour

The first hour after you find out is the most dangerous hour in this whole situation. Not because of what he did. Because of what shock makes you do.

What shock does to you

Your hands shake. Your thinking narrows to one point. You want the pain to stop, and the fastest way to make it stop feels like doing something huge, right now.

That feeling is normal. It is also lying to you. Almost everything you do in the first hour, you would do differently in three days.

The five things not to do tonight

Don't wake him and confront him. You are not ready, you have no plan, and he has every advantage at 2am.

Don't message the other woman. It feels like justice. In practice it warns them both, hands her a screenshot she can use against you, and turns your pain into gossip.

Don't call his family or yours. Not yet. The people you tell first shape everything that follows. Chapter 5 is about choosing them carefully.

Don't post anything. Not a quote, not a status, not a cryptic "God is watching." Whatever you post, you cannot take back, and it becomes the story people tell about you.

Don't make a decision. Not "I'm leaving," not "I'll forgive him." You do not have to decide anything tonight.

THE MISTAKE THIS CHAPTER EXISTS TO STOP

Sending one angry message "just to let him know you know." That one message gives him time to delete, prepare and get his version out first. Everything else in this book depends on you not sending it.

The three things to do tonight

One. Save what you saw. If you can do it without putting yourself at risk, take photos of the messages with your own phone, or note down the names, dates and exact words while they are fresh. Store them somewhere he cannot reach: an email account only you can open, or a trusted cloud folder.

Two. Put the phone back exactly as you found it. Same position, same screen, same volume.

Three. Get through the night. If you can't sleep beside him, have a simple reason ready to sleep elsewhere.

If he notices something is wrong

He may sense it. Your face may give you away. You do not have to lie, and you do not have to explain.

SCRIPT 1. For when he asks what's wrong tonight.

"I'm not feeling great and I'm tired. I don't want to talk tonight. We'll talk properly in a few days."

That is true, it is calm, and it buys you time without starting the conversation before you're ready.

ONE LINE ON CHECKING HIS PHONE

If you saw something by accident, or on a device you both use, save it and stop there. Do not try to get into his accounts, guess his passwords or install tracking apps. In Nigeria and many other countries, getting into someone else's phone or accounts without permission can be a criminal offence, and it gives him something to turn against you.

DO THIS NOW

Write down, in a note only you can see: what you saw, the date and time, and the name or number involved. Then close the note and try to rest. Tomorrow you start Chapter 2.

CHAPTER 2: Protect Yourself First

Before you think about him, think about you. There are three things to protect in the next 72 hours: your health, your money and your documents. Most women skip this step because the emotional pain feels bigger. Do it anyway. You will never regret having done it.

Your health

If there is any chance the affair was physical, get tested for sexually transmitted infections, including HIV, as soon as you can. Go to a hospital, a clinic or a laboratory you trust. HIV testing is often free or low-cost at government facilities.

Many infections show no symptoms at all, so "I feel fine" does not mean you are fine. Until you know more, protect yourself during sex, or don't have sex. You do not need to explain this decision to him yet.

THIS IS NOT ABOUT SHAME

Getting tested is not admitting that you did anything wrong. It is the most basic act of looking after yourself, and it gives you facts instead of fear.

Your money

This is the step women are least prepared for, and it can matter the most.

In a Zikoko feature on the financial consequences of divorce, a woman identified as Ronke, 34, described discovering her husband's cheating. After she confronted him, he asked for a divorce, and he withdrew ₦19 million from their ₦20 million joint account.

That is an extreme case. But the pattern is common: once he knows you know, money can move.

Before you confront him, quietly answer these questions:

- What accounts exist in your name, his name, and both names?
- Roughly how much is in each, as far as you know?
- What property, land, cars or business interests do you have together, and whose name are they in?
- Do you have money of your own you can reach today, without asking him?

If the answer to the last one is no, start an account in your name and keep a small amount there you can reach in an emergency. This is not stealing and it is not hiding. It is making sure you can buy food, pay transport and look after your children if things go badly.

DON'T TAKE WHAT ISN'T YOURS

Do not empty joint accounts or move money that isn't yours. It can damage your position later, legally and with family. Protect what is yours, know what exists, and leave the rest to a lawyer if it comes to that.

Your documents

Find and copy the papers that prove who you are and what you are entitled to:

- your marriage certificate, or proof of your traditional or religious marriage
- your children's birth certificates
- your own ID, passport and bank details
- any property papers, receipts or agreements in your name or both names

Take clear photos and store them where only you can reach them. If the originals are in a place he controls, knowing where they are is enough for now.

Your one person

You need one person, not ten. Someone who will listen without spreading it, who won't push you to stay or leave, and who you could call at 2am. A sister, a friend, a counsellor. Not someone connected to his family.

YOUR MOVE

1. Book your test this week.
2. Write down the accounts, property and documents you know about.
3. Make sure you can reach some money of your own.
4. Choose your one person.

CHAPTER 3: What You Actually Know

Before you confront him, you need to be clear about what you actually found, because it changes what you say and what you can expect.

The five levels

Not every discovery is the same. Be honest with yourself about which one this is.

Level 1: Flirting. Compliments, jokes, late-night "you up?" chats. Wrong, and a warning sign, but not yet proof of an affair.

Level 2: An emotional affair. Long, private, regular conversations with another woman. He tells her things he doesn't tell you. "My wife doesn't understand me."

Level 3: A physical affair. Messages, photos or plans that make it clear they have slept together.

Level 4: An ongoing relationship. It has been going on for months or years. Gifts, money sent, trips, a pattern.

Level 5: A second family. An outside child, a second home, or a woman who believes she is his wife.

WHY THE LEVEL MATTERS

The level changes your questions, your health steps and your timeline. Level 1 may be a conversation. Level 5 is a life decision with legal and financial weight. Don't treat a Level 1 like a Level 5, and don't let anyone talk you into treating a Level 4 like a Level 1.

What you don't know yet

Write two lists. On the left, what you saw with your own eyes. On the right, what you are imagining.

The right-hand list will feel just as real. It isn't evidence. It is pain filling the gaps. Keep it, but don't bring it into the confrontation. You will ask about it instead of accusing him of it.

Don't go digging for more

Once you've found something, the urge to find everything is overwhelming. Every new search feels like it will finally give you peace. It won't. It keeps you up all night and keeps the wound open.

You have enough to have the conversation. The conversation is where the rest comes out.

DO THIS NOW

Decide which level this is, honestly. Write it at the top of your note, then write your two lists underneath: what you saw, and what you fear.

CHAPTER 4: Confronting Him

You've protected your health and money. You know what you found. Now you are ready to talk, once and calmly.

Choose the time and place

Day three or later. Long enough to be calm, not so long that it eats you alive.

Sober, both of you. No drinks, no late-night fights.

Private, with the children away. Not in front of them, and not where they can hear.

Daytime or early evening. Not in bed at midnight.

Somewhere you can leave. You should be able to walk away if it gets heated.

SAFETY CHECK

If you have any fear of violence, do not confront him alone at home. Have someone nearby, choose a public place, or skip to Chapter 9 and plan with support first.

How to start

Say it once, plainly, with no long speech before it. Long introductions give him time to build his defence.

SCRIPT 2. The calm version, for most situations.

"I saw messages between you and [name]. I'm not going to shout. I want the truth, all of it, and I'll know if it isn't."

Then stop talking. Let the silence work. The first thing he says after that silence tells you a lot.

SCRIPT 3. The firm version, for when it is clearly physical or ongoing.

"I know about [name]. I've seen enough to know it isn't just talking. I'm not asking you whether it happened. I'm asking you to tell me how long, and whether it's over."

The five reactions, and what they tell you

He denies it completely. "It's nothing, you're imagining things." Calmly tell him what you saw, specifically, once. If he still denies what is in front of you, you have learned something important about how he handles truth.

He blames you. "If you gave me attention, I wouldn't..." This is the oldest move there is. Nothing you did made him lie to you.

He minimises. "It's just chatting." "She means nothing." Ask him one question: would he be comfortable if you had the same chats with another man?

He confesses part of it. He admits what you already know and nothing more. Ask: "Is there anything else I'm going to find out later? Tell me now, because later will be worse."

He gets angry or threatening. Stop the conversation. Leave the room. Your safety is not up for discussion.

When he turns it on you

Almost every confrontation hits this moment: "You went through my phone?"

SCRIPT 4. For when he makes it about your checking.

"We can talk about me seeing your phone after we talk about what I saw on it. One thing at a time."

SCRIPT 5. For when he says "you're overreacting."

"Maybe I am. I've just found out my husband has been lying to me. I think I'm allowed to react."

What you are trying to get from this conversation

Not an apology. Not a promise. Information.

- How long has it been going on?
- Is it over, and when did it end?
- Has money been involved?
- Is there a chance of a child, or an infection?
- Who else knows?

You don't have to decide anything at the end of this conversation. You can say:

SCRIPT 6. For ending the first conversation.

"Thank you for telling me. I need time to think. I'm not making any decision tonight, and I don't want you making promises tonight either."

THE THING NOT TO DO AFTER

Do not accept a big, tearful promise in the first hour and then act as if it's settled. Promises made in a crisis are easy. What he does over the next weeks is the real answer.

DO THIS NOW

Read Scripts 2 to 6 out loud twice, with the real name in them, until they sound like you. Then write your five questions on a piece of paper you can hold.

CHAPTER 5: "All Men Cheat": Family, In-Laws and the Pastor

At some point, other people will find out. Some will help. Many will tell you to endure.

What you will probably hear

"All men cheat." "At least he comes home." "Pray for him." "What did you do to push him?"
"Don't break your home over a small thing."

Some of the advice given publicly to women in this position has been worse. In 2024, a Nigerian clergyman told married women they needed "ashawo vibes" to stop their husbands cheating. Another pastor told wives to "confess righteousness" out of their cheating husbands. In September 2026, a woman's advice spread widely online: stay with your husband no matter what, because "a cheating husband is better than a dead one."

You are allowed to disagree with all of it. Being cheated on is not something you caused, and it is not something you have to accept to be a good woman.

Choose who you tell, and in what order

Tell your one person first (Chapter 2). Someone safe, private and on your side.

Tell family only when you know what you want from them. Support while you decide? Help with the children? A place to stay? Know your ask before you call.

Be very careful with his family. Many will protect him. Some will blame you. If his family must know, let it be after you have decided your next step, not before.

A pastor, imam or counsellor can help, if you trust them to listen rather than lecture. If the first thing they say is "endure," you can find someone else.

Scripts for the hardest conversations

SCRIPT 7. For your mother, or anyone who says "all men do it."

"Mummy, I'm not asking you whether to stay. I'm asking you to stand with me while I decide. Please don't tell me to endure. Just be on my side."

SCRIPT 8. For his family, if they call to pressure you.

"This is between me and my husband. I'm not discussing it right now. When we've decided what happens next, you'll hear it from us."

SCRIPT 9. For a pastor or elder who says it's your fault.

"I'm open to looking at my part in our marriage. But I didn't make him lie or cheat. I need help that starts there."

THE SENTENCE TO HOLD ON TO

You can respect your culture, your faith and your family and still refuse to carry blame that isn't yours.

YOUR MOVE

Write down the three people most likely to pressure you, and which script you'll use with each. Having the words ready is what stops you from crying on the phone and agreeing to things you don't mean.

CHAPTER 6: The Next 30 Days

The confrontation is over. Now comes the part nobody prepares you for: the ordinary days afterwards, when you still have to cook, work, look after children and sit across the table from him.

What the next weeks usually feel like

Some days you will feel strong and clear. Other days a song, a smell or his phone buzzing will knock you flat. You may swing between anger, sadness, numbness and wanting him close, sometimes in the same hour.

None of that means you are going mad or "not handling it well." It is what betrayal does to a person. It comes in waves, and the waves get further apart with time.

Look after your body first

Eat something, even if it's small. Shock kills appetite. Eat at regular times anyway.

Protect your sleep. If your mind races at night, write the thoughts down and tell yourself you'll deal with them in daylight.

Move a little. A walk, cleaning, anything that gets your body moving burns off some of the stress.

Watch what you're using to cope. Drinking more, scrolling all night or not getting out of bed for days are signs to reach for help.

Stop the 2am investigations

You will be tempted to check her social media, his location, his last seen, every hour. Each check feels like it will give you peace. It gives you a fresh wound.

Give yourself a rule: no checking after 9pm. If you need answers, write the question down and ask him in daylight, calmly, once.

Questions you still have

You will keep thinking of new questions. That is normal. Instead of firing them at him whenever they come, keep a list and agree on a time to talk, once or twice a week, for no more than an hour.

SCRIPT 10. For asking him to answer your questions without a fight.

"I still have questions, and I need honest answers to heal, whatever happens. Can we sit down on Saturday for an hour? I'll bring my list. I'm not trying to start a fight. I'm trying to understand."

Intimacy

You do not owe him intimacy to prove you've forgiven him, and you do not have to withhold it to prove you're hurt. Wait until your test results are back, and until you genuinely want to. If he pressures you, that tells you something about whether he understands what he's done.

The children

Children notice tension even when nobody says anything. Keep their routine as normal as you can. You don't need to tell them what happened. If they ask why you're sad, a short, true answer is enough: "Mummy and Daddy are working through a grown-up problem. You're safe and we love you."

Never ask a child to keep secrets, carry messages or choose sides.

When to get professional help

Talking to a counsellor is not only for marriages that are ending. It's for you. Consider it if, after the first couple of weeks, you can't sleep, can't eat, can't work, or can't stop thinking about it most of the day. If you ever have thoughts of harming yourself, tell someone you trust today and seek help immediately.

THE 30-DAY RULE

For the next 30 days, your only job is to stay safe, stay healthy and stay steady. Not to fix the marriage. Not to punish him. Not to make everyone understand. Steady first. Everything else comes after.

YOUR MOVE

1. Set your no-checking-after-9pm rule.
2. Start your question list and choose a weekly time to talk.
3. Write down one thing you will do each day this week just for you, however small.

CHAPTER 7: Stay or Leave: Your Decision

Everyone will have an opinion. Only one opinion has to live with the result: yours.

You don't have to decide this week

Some women know immediately. Most don't. Both are normal. If you don't know yet, give yourself a date, about 30 days from the confrontation, and promise yourself you'll decide by then.

The questions that matter

Answer these honestly, in writing, over a few days:

- Has he ended it completely, and can you check that it's ended?
- Did he tell you the truth when you asked, or only what you already knew?
- Is he taking responsibility, or blaming you?
- Is this the first time, or a pattern?
- Do you feel safe with him, physically and emotionally?
- If your daughter, sister or best friend were in your place, what would you want for her?
- Leaving aside what people will say, what do you want?

Reasons women stay that are worth questioning

"For the children." Children are affected by what they see every day. A calm home matters more to them than two parents under one roof in constant pain.

"Because of what people will say." People will talk either way. They will move on to the next story. You will still be living your life.

"Because I can't afford to leave." This one is real and serious. But it is a reason to make a plan, build your own money and get advice, not a reason to stop thinking.

Signs it may be time to go

- It is a long-term relationship or a second family, and he won't end it.
- It has happened before, and promises were broken.
- He blames you, mocks you or punishes you for finding out.
- He has given you an infection and lied about it.
- You are afraid of him.

THERE IS NO PERFECT ANSWER

Some women stay and rebuild something better. Some leave and build a better life. Both can be the right choice. What matters is that it is your choice, made with clear eyes, not one made for you by fear or by other people.

DO THIS NOW

Put your decision date in your calendar. Then answer the seven questions above in your note. Come back to them in a week and see if your answers have changed.

CHAPTER 8: If You Stay, If You Leave

Whichever way you go, there are practical steps that make it work.

If you stay

Staying only works on conditions. Without conditions, staying is just waiting for the next time.

Contact ends completely. Not "we're just friends." Ended, and he tells her so in a way you can confirm.

Full honesty, from now on. Answering your questions truthfully, even the uncomfortable ones.

Testing. Both of you, before you're intimate again.

Help. A counsellor, pastor or imam you both trust, who will hold him accountable and not just tell you to forgive.

Time. Trust comes back slowly. He doesn't get to decide when you should "be over it."

In Zikoko's series on married Nigerians who stayed after an affair, one woman, Jemimah, 36, described spending a year rebuilding her marriage, with trust slowly returning. That is normal. Rebuilding is not a single conversation.

SCRIPT 11. For setting your conditions.

"I'm willing to try, but only on these terms: it ends completely, you answer my questions honestly, we both get tested, and we see a counsellor. If any of that changes, so does my decision."

THE 90-DAY CHECK

Three months after you decide to stay, sit down alone and ask: is he keeping the conditions? Do I feel safer, or more anxious? Am I rebuilding, or just enduring? Your honest answer tells you whether staying is working.

If there is a child

If you've learned there is a child from the affair, everything feels heavier. Two things are true at once: the child did nothing wrong, and you are allowed to be devastated.

Don't make decisions about money, inheritance or contact in the first weeks. These have legal consequences that depend on your type of marriage and your country. Get legal advice before you agree to anything, and before anyone pressures you into "accepting" an arrangement.

If you leave

Leaving well is about planning, not drama.

Get legal advice early. Statutory, customary and Islamic marriages are ended in different ways, and the rules on children, property and maintenance depend on which you have. A lawyer will tell you in one conversation what applies to you. If you can't afford one, free legal aid exists in many countries, including Nigeria's Legal Aid Council, Ghana's Legal Aid Commission, Kenya's National Legal Aid Service and Legal Aid South Africa.

Plan for the children. Where they will live, school, and what you will tell them: short, true and not about blaming their father. "Mummy and Daddy are having grown-up problems. It's not your fault. We both love you."

Plan for money and housing. Where you'll stay, what you'll live on for the first three months, and what belongs to you.

Keep your records. The notes and documents from Chapter 2 matter here.

DON'T ANNOUNCE IT FIRST

Don't tell him you are leaving until your plan is ready, your documents are safe and you have somewhere to go, especially if there is any risk of anger or retaliation.

CHAPTER 9: When It's More Than Cheating

Sometimes cheating sits inside something more dangerous. If any of the following are true, this is not a confrontation problem. It is a safety problem.

Signs you need more than a conversation

- He has hit, pushed or choked you, or threatened to.
- He controls your money, your phone or where you can go.
- He threatens to take the children, or to hurt you or himself, if you leave.
- You are afraid of how he will react when he learns you know.

What to do

Make a quiet safety plan: a bag with essentials and documents at a trusted person's house, a phone number you can call, and a place you can go at any hour.

Get support from people trained to help. In Lagos, the Domestic and Sexual Violence Agency runs a free, confidential 24-hour line on 08000 333 333, with counselling, legal support and access to shelter. Wherever else you are, findahelpline.com lists free, confidential services by country, and your ministry for women or gender affairs, or the police gender desk, can refer you.

YOUR SAFETY COMES FIRST

Nothing in this book is worth more than your safety or your children's. If you are in danger right now, leave and call for help. Every other decision can wait.

IN PRACTICE: Seven Days, Start To Finish

Here is the whole plan in motion. This is a composite. It is not one woman's story and no real person is described.

Night one

Ada, 33, sees a message flash on her husband's phone while he is in the shower: "Missing you already. Same place Friday?"

She wants to scream. She doesn't. She photographs the message with her own phone, puts his back exactly where it was, and goes to sleep in the children's room. When he asks why, she says: "I'm not feeling great. We'll talk properly in a few days."

Day two

She books an STI test for the next morning. She checks which accounts she knows about and opens an account in her own name with ₦30,000 from her salary. She photographs her marriage certificate and the children's birth certificates.

She calls one person: her older sister, who lives in another city and has never liked gossip.

Day three

She writes down what she knows: Level 3, a physical affair, at least a few weeks. On the right-hand side she writes her fears: "He loves her. He'll leave. It's been years." She doesn't bring those into the conversation.

Day four

On Saturday afternoon, with the children at her sister-in-law's, she sits him down in the living room.

"I saw messages between you and Chioma. I'm not going to shout. I want the truth, all of it, and I'll know if it isn't."

He says she went through his phone. She replies: "We can talk about me seeing your phone after we talk about what I saw on it."

He admits it has been going on for four months. He says it's over. She asks her five questions and writes down his answers. Then she says: "Thank you for telling me. I need time to think. I'm not making any decision tonight."

Day five

His mother calls. Somebody has told her. "Every man has his weakness. Don't destroy your home."

Ada says: "This is between me and my husband. When we've decided what happens next, you'll hear it from us."

Day six

Her test results come back clear. She cries for the first time since Friday, out of relief.

Day seven

She puts a date in her calendar 30 days away. She doesn't know yet whether she'll stay. But she knows she's safe, her money and papers are protected, she has said what she needed to say, and every next step is hers.

WHAT THE SEVEN DAYS SHOW

Ada didn't need to be fearless. She needed an order to do things in, and the words ready when she needed them. That is what this book gives you.

CONCLUSION: Take Your Time. Take Your Power.

What you now have

A plan for the first hour, so shock doesn't make your choices for you. A checklist that protects your health, your money and your documents. A clear view of what you actually know. Eleven scripts for the conversations you've been dreading. And a way to make the stay-or-leave decision on your own terms.

THE WHOLE BOOK IN THREE SENTENCES

Don't confront him in shock. Protect yourself first, then speak once, calmly, with the words ready. Whatever you decide after that, decide it for you.

Tonight

Three things, and none of them takes long.

Save what you saw, somewhere only you can reach.

Write down the accounts, property and documents you know about.

Choose your one person, and put your test in your calendar.

You did not cause this. You do not have to rush. And you are going to be okay.

SOURCES

Quoted and cited: Zikoko features on the financial consequences of divorce and on married Nigerians who stayed after an affair; Linda Ikeji's Blog (2024) on the "ashawo vibes" sermon; Kemi Filani on the "confess righteousness" sermon; Ghanamma (September 2026) on the "a cheating husband is better than a dead one" advice. Helpline and legal-aid details were correct at the time of writing and should be confirmed before you rely on them. This book is general information, not legal, medical or professional counselling advice.

The Connection Code